civil liberties emerged, including a free press. Several opposition leaders openly emerged to challenge the legitimacy of the state. Aung Gyi gained a following, as well as former prime minister U Nu who claimed that the entire governing structure from 1962 to 1988 was illegal.

Law and order partially broke down because of the government's continued attempts to foster the chaos. Jails were empted, and looting and destruction was permitted by the military. Ultimately, these actions or inactions of September 1988 were a planned and coordinated effort to sow chaos so that the military could return to power. The regime formed an antistrike committee to discuss potential assassinations, dates for a coup d'état, and possible terrorists acts to facilitate the military's return.

The military continued to lay the groundwork for a potential coup. General Saw Maung stated that the people lived in fear and that they longed for peace and stability to return to Burma. The military also blamed the unrest of foreign elements that had infiltrated Burmese society. The tatmadaw claimed to be the defender of the Burmese nation.

Student leaders and protesters were unable to seize the moment. Intense factionalizations as well as a lack of coordination lessened the change for success. On September 12, the most significant threat to the regime emerged with the formation of the National League for Democracy (NLD). This coalition included the three most prominent opposition leaders, with Aung Gyi serving as party chairman, Tin U as vice chairman, and Aung San Suu Kyi as general secretary. The NLD wanted a formation of an interim government that would transition to a true democratic system.

THE ROLE OF AUNG SAN SUU KYI

The most prominent pro-democracy leader to emerge was Aung San Suu Kyi, daughter of the legendary founder of Burma, General Aung San. After high school Suu Kyi attended Lady Sri Ram College in Delhi, where she had moved with her mother in 1960. Her mother would be the ambassador to India from 1960 to 1967. Suu Kyi spent one year at Sri Ram College prior to gaining admission to St. Hugh's College, Oxford. She was one of the first Burmese to gain acceptance there.